SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

EXPLORING THE RELATIONSHIP OF LABOR PRACTICES AND WORK-LIFE BALANCE AMONG COURIER EMPLOYEES

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ABSTRACT

The rapid growth of e-commerce has increased job demands on courier employees, raising concerns about their work-life balance and well-being. This study examines the relationship between labor practices and work-life balance among courier employees, focusing on factors such as work environment, work conditions, health and safety, training, perceived fairness, psychological safety, and job satisfaction. Guided by the Job Demands–Resources (JD-R) model, the study explores how organizational practices influence workload, working hours, work stress, job engagement, and turnover intention. The findings aim to provide insights for employees, employers, and human resource practitioners in promoting fair labor practices and sustainable work-life balance in the courier industry.

CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

The growth of e-commerce and delivery services has transformed work for courier employees, now central to the supply chain, yet intensified job demands like tight deadlines, long hours, and performance pressures (Singh & Bhushan, 2023; Logistics Management, 2022). These challenges hinder work-life balance, creating personal difficulties and well-being concerns amid friction between demanding roles and personal lives (Mehta, 2023; Wood, 2021; Cahya & Pasek, 2023). This study thus explores how labor practices affect courier employees' ability to achieve sustainable work-life balance (Haar et al., 2022). This study aims to explore how labor practices affect the work-life balance of courier employees.

The organization's approach to managing its human capital directly impacts employee welfare and productivity (Armstrong, 2020). Labor practices refer to the rules, policies, and actions that organizations use to manage and treat their workers fairly (The Oxford Review, 2024). Good labor practices help create a safe, fair, and respectful workplace (The Oxford Review, 2024). According to the World Health Organization (2024), essential labor practices include providing fair pay, ensuring safety, offering training, and preventing discrimination. In this study, labor practices consist of several key variables: work environment, work conditions, health and safety, education and training, perceived fairness, psychological safety, and job satisfaction (Pang et al., 2023). These aspects play an essential role in improving employees' performance and well-being.

The findings from the study conducted at Davao City revealed that delivery riders experience a moderate level of job stress, particularly in terms of role expectation conflict, but benefit from high levels of co-worker support and work-life balance(Dela Cruz et al., 2025). Another study from Central Mindanao University employees considers social relationships and

activities, and community life as relatively encompassing their lives and are material(Jan et al., 2022). This has therefore led to giving more priority to work and putting on hold what they perceive as valuable activities and personal time; the quality of relationships is sacrificed to compensate for undone work. Work-life balance means managing both work and personal life healthily (OSHwiki, 2024). Having a good balance leads to higher job satisfaction and well-being, while poor balance can cause burnout, stress, and higher employee turnover (Majumder & Biswas, 2023; Hosseini et al., 2024). In this study, work-life balance focuses on Workload, working hours, and work stress (Natanael et al., 2023). It also includes turnover intention and job engagement, which are influenced by how well employees manage their work and personal lives (Jaharuddin and Zainol 2019).

Effective organizational support mechanisms are essential for mitigating job strain and promoting employee health and stability (Vazi et al., 2023). There is a strong relationship between labor practices and work-life balance, as explained by the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model—validated among Philippine delivery riders facing job stress yet benefiting from peer support (Jaharuddin & Zainol, 2019; Ilac et al., 2022). Poor labor practices, such as unsafe conditions or unfair treatment, increase job stress and create work-life conflict, as evidenced in Davao City courier studies showing moderate stress from heavy workloads (World Health Organization, 2024; Dela Cruz et al., 2025). On the other hand, good labor practices like fair treatment, flexible schedules, and supportive management help reduce stress and improve balance, with Filipino dual-income workers using crafting strategies like financial management to enhance well-being (Chung & Van der Lippe, 2020; Ahmed et al., 2024; Caringal-Go & Hechanova, 2024). This study will explore the relationship of labor practices and work-life balance among courier employees.

The study will be significant for various stakeholders, including courier employees, employers, customers, students of human resource management, and prospective researchers, as it examines the relationship between labor practices and employees' work-life balance in the courier industry. The study will benefit Courier employees by promoting fair labor practices and improving their work-life balance, enabling them to be more productive and provide better service. For the employers, it offers clear insights into the strengths and weaknesses of their current management policies, enabling them to develop strategies that enhance delivery riders' satisfaction, retention, productivity, and long-term sustainability. Customers can use the findings to understand how labor practices affect work-life balance and to drive service improvements. The students of Human Resource Management will benefit because the outcomes of this research will enhance their understanding of the practical value of labor relations and employee management theories. It will also provide them with pertinent knowledge to develop and establish effective labor practices that enhance a healthy work-life balance, thereby facilitating a more sustainable and productive workforce. Additionally, the study lays a foundation for future research, encouraging exploration of the relationship between labor practices and work-life balance among the courier employees.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

This chapter reviews studies related to the research variables. It covers independent variables such as the respondents' demographic profile, including age, sex, civil status, educational attainment, years of experience job position, and years in business. The review also examines labor practices related to the work environment, work conditions, health and safety, education and training, perceived fairness, psychological safety, and job satisfaction (Pang et al., 2023). Furthermore, it discusses the dependent variables, which will focus on work-life balance, Workload, working Hours, and work stress (Natanael et al., 2023). Diani Lestaria and Meily Margaretha (2021) state that job engagement and turnover intention are also part of the work-life balance. Labor practices refer to the rules, policies, and actions that organizations use to manage and treat their workers fairly (The Oxford Review, 2024). The need to continue delivering excellent work has a direct effect on how couriers operate. While work-life balance is one of the most important issues that human resource management should address in organizations (Abdirahman et al., 2020). Regardless of their size, organizations should ensure that employees have adequate time to fulfill their family and work commitments (Abdirahman et al., 2020). Work-life balance refers to balancing one's professional work, family responsibilities, and other personal activities (Jermsittiparsert, 2020).

In the modern organizational environment, characterized by globalization, technological progress, and the emergence of non-standard work models such as the gig economy, it is crucial to understand the factors that determine employees' well-being and performance (Ghosh and Kuttan, 2022; Rodriguez-Sanchez et al., 2020). To increase their revenue, many feel obliged to take deliveries during rush hours or during inclement weather. In order to reach delivery goals and earn bonuses, this performance pressure also pushes couriers to work long hours, frequently without enough rest, which exacerbates the physical demands of the job (Veen et al., 2020). While food

delivery services in Sweden highlight the flexibility of gig labor, couriers frequently feel pressured to work excessive hours in order to achieve their financial targets because their pay is erratic and contingent upon changing demand (Huws et al., 2019). With the COVID-19 pandemic, which affected the whole world, significant changes have occurred in working life. Some of these changes affected the employees permanently and some temporarily. While there are changes in working life, working hours, and work-life balance with the COVID-19 pandemic, new criteria in terms of occupational health and safety standards and pandemic-specific criteria have also entered the working life quickly. Although this rapid change has caused some specific changes in the lives of almost everyone, it has also brought up common problems and solutions for workplaces and employees (Leka et al., 2024).

Workforce demographic information, such as age, Sex, civil status, educational level, and years of service, is a layer of analysis. These attributes tend to buffer employees' perceptions and responses towards the workplace and corporate policies (Fernandez, 2022; Lagrana, 2021). Indicatively, research indicates that age can affect stress levels and work-life balance requirements, whereas Sex often intersects with societal norms and needs, posing a special challenge to women in the workforce, especially in male-dominated industries (Esguerra, 2020; Micha et al., 2022). Through this analysis of these demographic factors, the review will seek to discover the subtle mechanisms.

In addition to personal traits, this review delves deeper into the critically important role of labor practices. The behaviors that shape a company's tangible policies and intangible cultural norms are strong predictors of employee performance. The main practices being examined include the working environment, general working conditions, health and safety measures, and education and training opportunities. Positive attitudes and behaviors of employees are

consistently developed through supportive, fair, and safe labor practices (Pang et al., 2023; Yoon et al., 2021).

Work-life balance is now one of the key concepts of modern organizational psychology, and a large body of literature has already identified it as the antecedent of almost all the vital employee and organizational outcomes, such as job satisfaction, performance, commitment, and retention (Marecki and Tibbot, 2023; Kerdpitak and Jermsittiparsert, 2020). Workload and working hours are directly linked to these notions, which are often the primary causes of issues in this balance. The evidence in other sectors, such as express delivery in China and banking in Nigeria, shows that work overloads and long working hours are direct antecedents of stress, burnout, and poor well-being (Hong et al., 2022; Ngozi and Chinelo, 2020; Wen et al., 2021). One outcome of these pressures is work stress, a serious problem for personal health and organizational output.

Work Environment

Work environment refers to the physical, social, and psychological situations in which employees undertake their responsibilities. The working environment includes the employees' physical (e.g., lighting, ventilation, and leisure facilities) and psychological aspects, such as public discussion and psychological comfort (Ali et al., 2021). The literature shows that a positive work environment is among the vital antecedents of job satisfaction and also a counter to job stress. Empowering riders with knowledge of their rights and union support will enable them to advocate for safer, more supportive work environments (Luca Boniardi et al., 2024). These measures aim to better safeguard the rest rights of dedicated delivery riders as new-form employees in the digital economy (Ziyi Li, et.al, 2025)

According to Butt et al. (2020), an analysis of the telecommunications industry in Pakistan indicates that the work environment plays a significant mediating role, with intense mediation between benefits and salary/employee job satisfaction. This fact implies that, despite

the high salary, employee satisfaction tends to depend primarily on the quality of the environment and social relations. The positive moderating effect of good management and a healthy environment was also observed in the same study, which revealed that a supportive work environment, coupled with effective leadership, positively moderated the connection with job satisfaction.

The study on courier services also highlights the significance of the work environment, which is often highly pressurized and stressful. Research on couriers in the Chinese e-commerce market found that one of the most significant social-sustainability practices was enhancing the working environment, which was associated with a substantial positive influence on job satisfaction (Pang et al., 2023). This was mediated by improved perceptions of fairness and psychological safety, implying that a good environment indicates to employees that the company cares about their well-being. The talent retention model in a multinational technological and tourism company also mentions that one of the key factors enhancing employee loyalty and satisfaction is a positive and conducive working environment (Rodríguez-Sánchez et al., 2020). All these studies show that the work environment is not a passive setting where work occurs, but rather a dynamic component in influencing the attitudes and performance of employees. Stress can be increased by an ineffective environment and reduced by a supportive one. Additionally, other advantages can be improved, and a feeling of psychological well-being can be promoted.

Work Conditions

Working conditions include the company's benefits to employees, such as remuneration, working hours, contract systems, and other employee benefits (Tran et al., 2021). The terms of employment and the realities of working conditions are related to the nature of a job and its operation, including contractual terms, wages, work volume, and control. The literature, particularly studies on the gig economy and courier services, indicates a significant discrepancy

between the promise of new workplace practices and the frequently precarious reality for employees. A combination of economic and technological factors shapes the working conditions of last-mile delivery workers. Algorithmic management systems, which prioritize speed and efficiency, often impose tight delivery schedules and performance-based compensation schemes that can contribute to fatigue, stress, and burnout (Laskaris et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2022).

Studies of motor couriers in Türkiye highlight direct opposition to the cooler rhetoric of flexibility and high profit margins, as well as the experiences of self-employed platform workers (Demir and Özkan, 2025). The researchers found that such couriers worked longer hours, experienced greater work-life imbalance, and lacked genuine autonomy compared to salaried workers. Most of them claimed that they could not control their workdays or hours, which directly opposes the main idea of platform work. This implies that their status as self-employed is merely formal, and in reality, they are de facto employees without the relevant protections (Demir & Özkan, 2025). Equally, a qualitative study of women in the platform economy in India found that, despite access to the labor market, this access often leads to a loss of stable incomes, excessive working hours, and the absence of social safety nets (Ghosh and Kuttan, 2022).

In more traditional conditions of employment, poor working conditions are also associated with adverse outcomes. An investigation of motorcycle food delivery riders in Thailand revealed that pressure from customer rating systems is a significant issue related to working conditions and traffic accidents (Kwangsi K. Stith et al., 2024). On the other hand, the positive effects of improving working conditions are shown to have a powerful influence. An analysis of Chinese couriers revealed that an improved working environment, determined by aspects such as compensation and benefits, had the most significant positive impact on perceived fairness and psychological safety, subsequently enhancing job satisfaction (Pang et al., 2023). According to the Labor Code of the Philippines In terms of remuneration according to DOLE the Equal Pay for Equal

Work Principle, found in the Wage Rationalization Act (R.A. 6727) and clarified by DOLE orders, ensures equal pay for work of equal value, regardless of gender. When talking about the employees leaves. Article 95 of the Labor Code of the Philippines grants every employee who has rendered at least one year of service a yearly Service Incentive Leave (SIL) of five days with pay. For the equal treatment that is necessary for the whole organisation or any company the Republic Act (RA) 6725, the Magna Carta enacted in the Philippines in 1989, is a landmark law strengthening the prohibition of gender discrimination in employment, ensuring equal pay, promotions, and opportunities for women by amending the Labor Code and holding violators criminally liable, promoting fairness in terms and conditions of work.

Health and Safety

As gig economy workers, couriers are often treated as independent contractors rather than employees, which limits employer accountability for their safety and shifts the responsibility onto the individual (Tran et al., 2022). Consequently, couriers must manage their own safety while working in hazardous environments. Occupational health and safety (OHS) is an essential aspect of labor practice, especially within industries significantly affected by physical hazards, such as the courier and delivery sector. The dangers to this workforce's health and safety, exacerbated by the gig economy and other factors such as the COVID-19 pandemic, are widely reported in the reviewed literature. These delivery riders are frontliners who execute critical duties in the logistics value chain. The business operators should also provide adequate remuneration, social security, and health and safety safeguards to their riders to ensure their well-being (Binghay, Virgel C. et.al, 2022)

According to several studies, accidents and physical ailments are very common among couriers. A study conducted in Israel revealed that 13 percent of couriers had been in a road accident due to their work, and 37 percent came across musculoskeletal pain at least once a day

(Egozi et al., 2021). The research attributed accidents to long working hours and stress, citing mediating behavior, such as driving when feeling unwell. It attributed stress and parcel weight to musculoskeletal pain. Likewise, the chart review of an Australian ED identified that injured food delivery riders were primarily young, male, non-residents with fractures and other injuries because of collisions, and very few of them had access to workers' compensation (McKinlay et al., 2022). These results create an image of an exposed workforce that is under serious physical threat and has no sufficient safety nets.

Both effective leadership and organizational practices are found to be important in reducing these risks. Research in Venezuela established that a transformational style of leadership, one that encourages worker inclusion and participation, directly and positively impacted the OHS management performance in courier companies (De Pablos et al., 2024). This implies that safety is not limited to compliance with regulations but involves proactively creating a culture of safety. Moreover, the study of Chinese couriers found that the organization's investments in health and safety, including the provision of protective equipment and health screenings, significantly increased employment satisfaction by enhancing employees' psychological safety and fairness perceptions (Pang et al., 2023). The facts all point to the conclusion that health and safety must not be left to individual responsibility, particularly in a precarious and pressurized workforce. The welfare of these indispensable workers is in dire need of proactive organizational measures, good leadership, and regulatory reforms.

Education and Training

According to Trmcico, Demmings, Kniel, Wiedmann, and Alcaine 2021), training employees on proper precautions during the COVID-19 pandemic can help reduce cross-infection among employees. In this study, the education and training of couriers include the conventional sense (e.g., job skills, related knowledge, etc.) and the non-conventional sense (e.g., providing

epidemic prevention guidance for employees). Helping employees improve their job skills and enrich their work-related knowledge can increase employees' expectations and rewards for the future. Training and education are essential human resource management (HRM) practices and a significant investment in human capital by an organization. The literature agrees that providing learning opportunities and development is positively correlated with outcomes such as improved employee performance, job satisfaction, and motivation. Workers think that appropriate procedures should be used to deliver training, that needs assessments should be carried out before choosing training topics, and that further career development should be established to increase employee performance (Biscocho et al., 2025).

Other studies draw a direct correlation between the training and performance. A recent systematic literature review of human capital proved that investment in employee development in terms of training has a positive impact on employee performance and the general productivity of an organization (Arokiasamy, 2023). It is justified by the fact that studies on millennial workers in the COVID-19 pandemic have revealed that e-training had a substantial positive impact on motivation to work and the performance of employees (Wolor et al., 2020). On the same note, research on front-line hotel workers in China established that training had a meaningful positive impact on task performance, both directly and indirectly via enhanced job satisfaction (Luo et al., 2021).

Training also helps increase employee satisfaction and engagement, but the correlation is delicate. An examination of Chinese couriers found that education and training were beneficial social sustainability practices that positively influenced job satisfaction (Pang et al., 2023). Nevertheless, in a study conducted at a Malaysian courier service company, the authors did not identify any significant correlation between the training and the overall satisfaction with the job, indicating that the nature, quality, and subject of the training might be essential (Desa & Soid,

2020). Strategically, a systematic Training Needs Analysis is deemed instrumental in making sure that the efforts in development are focused and effective as a part of an integrated Human Capital Strategic framework (Febrian, 2023). The pieced evidence, in totality, points to the fact that training is vital labor practice. Properly applied, it not only equips employees with the skills required to perform their tasks efficiently but also demonstrates the organization's investment in them, increasing motivation, satisfaction, and performance.

Perceived Fairness

Perceived fairness or organizational justice is a concept that describes how employees view the fairness of outcomes, workplace procedures, and the relationship between themselves and others. The literature recognizes it as a pivotal psychological process that moderates the influence of organizational practices and employee attitudes, especially job satisfaction. Once they feel they are being treated fairly, employees will have more positive feelings towards their job and the organization. Organizational fairness refers to employees' perceptions and internal judgments of whether they are treated fairly by their organization. When employees perceive higher levels of fairness, they are more inclined to seek organizational support to accomplish tasks, which in turn reduces feelings of job burnout and decreases turnover intentions (Lei Tong, et.al, 2024)

An analysis of the couriers in the Chinese online shopping market is a good example of this dynamic. The study was based on the equity theory and focused on the relationship between social-sustainability practices and job satisfaction, and revealed that the perceived fairness played a significant mediating role (Pang et al., 2023). The research also found that the positive impact of working conditions, health and safety, and training on job satisfaction among couriers was significant because these practices made them feel fairly treated. The most important positive

influence on perceived fairness was improvements in working conditions, including compensation and benefits (Pang et al., 2023).

This implies that fair treatment is not an abstract idea but a connotation derived from observable organizational behaviors. By making the employees feel important in terms of their health and growth, the company sends a strong message that it cares about them, and this creates a sense of fairness. This implication to managers is that policies are not only a tool to reach operational objectives; a policy also constitutes a message that either promotes or deters employees' perception of justice. To improve job satisfaction and address social sustainability, courier companies and other organizations should consider practices that strengthen this sense of fairness. From a key psychological perspective, perceived fairness, the study can contribute to the literature by empirically identifying concrete labor practices that enhance job satisfaction, a key element of a positive and sustainable working environment.

Psychological Safety

According to Moin et al. (2021), Psychological safety is a state of mind in which employees feel protected and share openly without jeopardizing their careers, jobs, or status, creating a positive work atmosphere in their organization. Psychological safety is the mutual trust of the team members that the work environment is a safe place to take interpersonal risks. It implies that the employees have no fear of being punished or humiliated because they feel free to express their ideas, ask questions, raise concerns, or even admit mistakes. According to Cheung, F., et al. (2025), platform work offers flexibility and autonomy that traditional jobs often lack. However, this freedom comes with significant trade-offs, particularly concerning worker well-being.

Edmondson (2019) explains psychological safety as "setting the stage for a more honest, more challenging, more collaborative and thus also more effective work environment" (p. 18). Feeling psychologically safe allows for setting ambitious goals and working together as a group

towards their achievement. There are four stages of psychological safety. Inclusion safety identifies you as feeling like a member of the group or team, learner safety allows you to ask questions within the group without criticism or demeaning comments from other group members, contributor safety, which encourages you to contribute your ideas or opinions to those in charge without the fear that your ideas or suggestions will be ignored and or not acknowledged, and challenger safety, which allows you to challenge the current process or method of operating without fear of retribution. The four stages can be explained by defining behaviors that align with definitions of respect, permission, and an actionable social exchange to help explain how psychological safety can be identified in the group (Clark, 2020). However, no matter how inclusive the culture is, past experiences, observations, foreperson training, and team dynamics can be critical in how crew members are viewed and treated inclusively or not Hofstede Insights, 2023).

This idea focuses on a study of the effect of social-sustainability practices on the job satisfaction of couriers, in particular during the COVID-19 pandemic (Pang et al., 2023). The study, based on the psychological safety theory, found that job satisfaction among couriers improved significantly through practices that improved the working environment, working conditions, and health and safety measures. Psychological safety was a powerful mediator of this relationship; in other words, these supportive practices helped staff members to feel safer and more secure in their jobs, which consequently worked to their satisfaction (Pang et al., 2023). The paper points out that employee health and safety measures, including protective equipment and regular health checks, are especially effective at instilling a sense of psychological safety. It also makes the employees feel safe and appreciated when they realize that the employer is indeed interested in their welfare. Such a feeling of security is essential in the industry where employees have to face everyday physical hazards and job insecurity.

Job Satisfaction

Job satisfaction is a widely studied concept in organizational behavior studies, often defined as the extent to which people enjoy their work. It is one of the components of the highest stages (i.e., self-actualization) of Maslow's hierarchy-of-needs theory. Research shows that whether an organization is fair can affect employees' job performance and job satisfaction. The positive changes in fair perception have a positive impact on job satisfaction and vice versa. This change is because employees who experience organizational justice tend to engage in positive work behaviors, such as continuous self-improvement, and are satisfied with their work (Pang et al., 2023).

There are many antecedents of job satisfaction. It has been demonstrated that a welcoming work atmosphere, strong communication from supervisors, benefits, and pay have a considerable positive influence on job satisfaction (Butt et al., 2020; Desa and Soid, 2020). Job satisfaction is another factor that is promoted by formal organizational resources such as training and supervisor mentoring that boost job performance (Luo et al., 2021). Additionally, social-sustainability practices, including enhancement of working conditions, health and safety, improvement in job satisfaction due to the promotion of a sense of fairness and psychological security in employees (Pang et al., 2023). There is also a close connection between work-life balance and job satisfaction; the more employees can easily balance their professional and personal lives, the higher their levels of job satisfaction (Fernandez, 2022; Kuranga, 2020).

On the other hand, lower job satisfaction is linked to other factors, such as work stress and work-life imbalance (Irawanto et al., 2021). An example of the study of bank employees in Ethiopia demonstrated that employees could find meaning in their work (positive job characteristic), but they were not overall satisfied because they did not have a chance to progress and enhance (Buba & Tanchi, 2024). Low job satisfaction has dire effects, and an increasing

employee turnover rate is often a significant sign of the issue (Desa & Soid, 2020). The available literature is clear that job satisfaction is a complex variable influenced by numerous organizational factors. To managers, the implication means that job satisfaction is a holistic process that cannot be achieved only through compensation but also through the creation of a favorable working environment, growth, supportive leadership, and a healthy work-life balance.

Workload

Workload is the amount of work or tasks that must be completed by a person or group of individuals within a specific period of time (Sari & Ali, 2022). It consist of various activities, duties, and obligations that a person must undertake in their work environment. Workload involves not only the number of tasks or jobs to be completed but also the complexity, difficulty, and pressure associated with each job (Midha et al., 2021). Excessive or unbalanced Workload can result in stress, fatigue, and negative influences on one's physical and mental well-being (Hernandez et al., 2021). The subdimensions of Workload, according to Hart (Xi et al., 2023), include mental demands, physical demands, temporal demands, effort, performance, and frustration. When employees feel their Workload is high, it can affect their personal lives, which in turn can lead to low performance (Syihabudhin et al., 2020).

Dong et al. (2025), Laskaris et al. (2024), and Nguyen-Phuoc et al. (2023, 2024) studies indicate that high workloads and a lack of control over working conditions are determinants of burnout among delivery riders. Studies by Laskaris et al. (2024) and Nguyen-Phuoc et al. (2023, 2024) highlight high workloads and limited control over working conditions as key determinants of burnout among riders. Some research studies identify heavy workloads as a direct factor in stress and work-life imbalance. In a study conducted at a policy institute on agricultural policies in Zambia, excessive workloads with inadequate deadlines were found to be the main factor that contributes to stress among employees (Lukama, 2020). On the same note, workload pressure was

identified as having a significant, negative impact on employee productivity, accounting for a large percentage of the variance in performance (Ngozi & Chinelo, 2020). This implies that there is a limit beyond which the extra Workload will be associated with declining returns, as employees become exhausted and less effective.

Workload is a key variable that mediates the correlation between social stressors and negative outcomes in the courier and delivery industry. An investigation on Chinese courier drivers established that customer-related stressors, including verbal aggression and unclear expectations, were not directly linked to turnover intentions. Instead, their adverse influence was entirely mediated by Workload; a combination of high Workload and a poor social environment was what made a driver significantly more willing to leave the industry (Wen et al., 2021). That point underscores that Workload may be a multiplier of other job stressors. The implication for the management is clear: organizations need to manage the workloads to curb stress, avoid burnout, and increase productivity. This means assigning work properly, setting appropriate deadlines, and giving employees the means and tools to fulfill their duties without being overwhelmed (Lukama, 2020; Ngozi and Chinelo, 2020).

Working Hours

Working Hours are the specific period of time during which a person is employed or expected to work, in accordance with company or government regulations and policies. Regarding working hours, Komari et al. (2023) revealed that Work-Life Balance involves many aspects, such as working hours, level of flexibility, well-being, family characteristics, demographic factors, migration experience, leisure time, and so on. Long working hours are a common phenomenon in most organizations and companies, where the duration of time spent working. This phenomenon includes situations in which workers must work for periods exceeding healthy work-life balance standards (Wong et al., 2019). The impact of long working hours can be very detrimental to

workers' well-being (Magnavita et al., 2021). Research findings by Hsu et al. (2019) show that Working Hours have a positive effect on Work-Life Balance. However, the results of this study are not consistent with the research findings (Badri et al., 2022), which indicate that working time harms employee quality of life.

Working hours are a fundamental labor practice with direct and significant consequences for employee health, safety, and work-life balance. An analysis of express delivery courier companies in China shows good evidence of this relationship. The study observed that the prevalent pattern of long working hours (>48 hours per week) was typical among 75% of couriers and directly affected depression and occupational stress, and had a negative direct impact on well-being (Hong et al., 2022). This implies that excessive working hours are an influential indicator of poor mental health in this workforce. On the same note, studies of Israeli couriers found that long working hours and stress were associated with road accidents, mediated by driving behavior when feeling unwell (Egozi et al., 2021). This provides a clear path to a work schedule for vital safety outcomes.

The effect of working hours goes beyond physical and mental health to directly affect work-life balance. According to Demir and Özkan (2025), an examination of self-employed motor couriers in Türkiye found that they worked more hours and were more likely to be burdened by work-life imbalance than their salaried peers, directly contradicting the concept of flexibility in the gig economy. Nevertheless, working hours are not necessarily interconnected with well-being. An analysis of public sector workers in Pontianak City revealed that workplace burnout negatively impacted well-being, with working hours not being significant (Rosnani, 2023). This implies that the stressfulness and difficulty of the work (burnout) can be of greater concern for the welfare of some employees than the number of hours worked. A study of public sector employees in Indonesia found that working hours did not have a significant impact on work-life balance or well-

being, suggesting that factors such as job burnout were more critical in that context (Rosnani, 2023). Nonetheless, for physically and mentally demanding roles like those in the courier industry, managing working hours remains a crucial lever for protecting employee well-being.

Work Stress

Work stress is a condition of tension or psychological pressure experienced by a person due to factors related to their work. This is caused by various pressures, demands, and conflicts that arise in the work environment that can affect a person's physical and mental well-being (Irawanto et al., 2021). The research conducted by Boamah et al. (2022) and Massoud et al. (n.d.) shows that Work Stress is positively correlated with Work-Life Balance. However, this research is not in line with previous research (Aruldoss et al., 2021; Saratian et al., 2019), which shows that Work Stress negatively affects Work-Life Balance. Work stress, the negative responses individuals exhibit to undue pressures or other forms of work demand, is a well-documented phenomenon in the literature and a significant indicator of low employee well-being. It is demonstrated as the result of challenging labor practices and as the cause of adverse organizational outcomes, including diminished performance and elevated turnover.

The antecedents of work stress are numerous and well-documented. Overworking, unmet deadlines, role confusion, excessive working hours, and work insecurity are also considered main contributors to stress (Egozi et al., 2021; Hong et al., 2022; Lukama, 2020). The social and interpersonal factors are also influential. The burden courier drivers face includes customer-related social stressors (Wen et al., 2021). In addition, work-life domain inequity is also significantly linked to increased job stress (Esgueria, 2020). Demographic vulnerabilities also play a prominent role in the literature, where younger, less educated employees tend to be more stressed (Esguerra, 2020).

According to Kerdpitak and Jermsittiparsert (2020), the effects of high work stress are dire. It is also a powerful indicator of an employee's intent to leave. It also has a detrimental impact on job satisfaction and may lead to burnout, thereby reducing employees' well-being (Irawanto et al., 2021; Rosnani, 2023). Poor health and diminished safety are also linked to stress, as observed among couriers, who reported stress-related musculoskeletal pain and an increased risk of road accidents (Egozi et al., 2021). Surprisingly, some research works report counterintuitive results. In their ultimate models, studies of the banking sector and telecom sector of Pakistan established that job stress did not have a direct significant impact on work-life balance or job satisfaction, implying that its effect might be offset by other variables such as personality or work environment (Butt et al., 2020; Zahoor et al., 2021). However, there has been excessive agreement that work stress is harmful. This places a strong obligation on organizations to have proactive plans to reduce stressors and safeguard employees' health, enhance retention, and create a healthy working environment.

Turnover Intention

Turnover intention is an employee's desire to transfer to a new job that is better than the employee's prior employment and more in line with the employee's desires. When leaving their previous positions voluntarily, workers convey this goal. The possibility that an employee plans to leave their workplace or look for a new job is called turnover intention (Dharma, 2020). According to Handoko (2019), an employee can resign if he sees greater career opportunities elsewhere. Job turnover intention is defined as "a conscious and deliberate willingness to leave an organization." 17 Although no standard framework has been developed to understand why employees leave voluntarily, factors such as poor workplace communication, hostile work environment, unexplained work tasks, inequitable salary and benefits packages, have been implicated (Ofei-Dodoo et al. 2020).

Turnover intention can result from the company's wishes, employees' wishes, or other factors, such as the expiration of the employment contract between the employee and the company (Saputro et al., 2020). When turnover occurs, a company loses its workforce. This labor vacancy leaves tasks unfinished, leading to neglect. With this, it is necessary to recruit new employees.

Therefore, an employee's turnover intention can be used as a strategy to prevent turnover, as it often predicts actual quitting behavior within the organization (Windon et al., 2019). Employees are essential to an organization's success, and as such, they should be valued, as there are several costs associated with the loss of an employee, whether direct or indirect. The various expenditures may include those associated with recruiting, selection, and training.

Employee turnover and intention to quit have been among the most widely investigated organizational phenomena (Hur and Abner, 2024; Leon and Garcıa-Saavedra, 2021; Ng et al., 2019). Understanding turnover is significant to human resources and career management (Verbruggen and van Emmerik, 2020). In this section, the focus is on one specific turnover cognition variable, the antecedent variable, turnover intention (Klotz et al., 2021; Peltokorpi et al., 2023), as it is significant about employee satisfaction (with their job, the organization or both), and may therefore impact job performance among other variables, such as career satisfaction (Verbruggen and van Emmerik, 2020). Further, the turnover intention construct is less well understood than job performance, and unpacking it is necessary because it underpins the hypothesis development.

Researchers have endeavored to determine the leading causes of employee turnover (or turnover intention) in various industries. Recent meta-analytic studies reveal many such turnover predictors. Reviewing 101 turnover studies conducted in the U.S during the 1998-2018 period, for example, Özkan et al. (2020) identified job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and

empowerment as three key antecedents of turnover. Similar research efforts in the hospitality industry also found several key predictors of employee turnover; negative predictors included, for example, job satisfaction, organizational commitment, work engagement, performance, leadership, and managerial support, while positive predictors consisted of burnout, job stress, role conflicts, emotional labor, and organizational politics (Han, 2020; Park and Min, 2020). A considerable amount of effort has been devoted to understanding variables that increase or decrease TI, because turnover is a threat to effective organizations (Özkan et al., 2020).

Factors that contribute to high turnover intention among driver partners are work-life balance, organizational commitment, and rewards (Kaushalya & Perera, 2018; Chua & Ng, 2023; De Gieter et al., 2012). Work-life balance, or the balance between work and personal life, is essential, considering that drivers work without clear time limits (Oosthuizen et al., 2019; Kakar et al., 2021). When this balance is disturbed, psychological pressure can arise that encourages the intention to quit work. Drivers who feel appreciated, have a sense of belonging to the company, and believe in the company's vision and mission tend to stay longer. Conversely, low organizational commitment can increase the risk of turnover intention.

Job Engagement

Job engagement is a work-related state that is characterized by vigor, dedication, and absorption (Bakker et al., 2020). It refers to one's active allocation of personal resources and energies in performing their job (Eldor et al., 2020). Job engagement is a display of vigor, dedication, and absorption in one's job. It is an undefined force that inspires employees to move toward advanced stages of performance and illustrates the degree to which workers are satisfied with their occupations, feel appreciated in their roles, and experience teamwork and trust. Job engagement is an individual's participation and satisfaction, reflected in their eagerness for work and the intense effort they put into their work. Engaged employees generally feel involved, loyal,

enthusiastic, and empowered, and exhibit those feelings in their work behavior. More specifically, such employees have great energy, are passionate about their work, and are often fully absorbed in it, such that time passes quickly in their eyes, which will significantly contribute to the organization's productivity, efficiency, and effectiveness, with lower employee turnover rates (Sepahvand et al. 2020).

Given the importance of energy and resources in enabling job engagement, Kahn's seminal work emphasizes availability as a critical psychological condition conducive to engagement, with the vast majority focusing on either external job characteristics or psychological traits that can increase employees' resource repertoire (Sonnentag et al., 2020). However, upon returning to the workplace, it becomes essential to understand which actions employees can take to reignite their post-return job engagement.

Engagement can be defined as "the creation of opportunities for communication between employees largely and easily", and it also involves establishing an encouraging and motivating environment that meets employees' desire to communicate with their work, in addition to supporting proper job performance (Alhozi et al. 2021). As a pioneer in job engagement literature, Kahn (1990) suggested three dimensions of job engagement based on previous studies: physical engagement, emotional engagement, and cognitive engagement. Hence, we can see that "engagement" comprises emotional, mental, and behavioral components, meaning that engaged employees are naturally invested in organizations through their bodies, minds, and souls. However, the majority of the existing literature has addressed job engagement as one block, rather than in its three dimensions (Deepa, 2020).

According to Aggarwal (2022), employees need to build resilience in a dynamic workplace to improve their performance and engagement, both organizational and personal. Their dedication to their job might eventually lead to higher performance and organizational success.

Meanwhile, they will be more likely to attend job events and take an active role at work. Furthermore, the concept of engagement is associated with effectiveness, innovation, productivity, and organizational expenses and benefits. Aggarwal (2022) asserted the interrelatedness between resilience and job engagement. Researchers argued that in job engagement, employees use their personalities, emotions, and physical behaviors to link to their role performance(Edelia & Aslami, 2022). Nonetheless, employees intend to implement physical and emotional behaviors to move away from similar scenarios, particularly if they feel they are disengaged with the job.

Employees' work–life balance is crucial for achieving job engagement and job performance because it directly influences their physical and mental well-being, job satisfaction, commitment to work, and overall capacity to contribute effectively to the organization's success (Yadav et al., 2022). When workers are personally invested in their jobs, they are more likely to show loyalty and dedication to the company (Ismail, 2023). For instance, an investigation by Abdulaziz et al. (2022) into the education sector highlighted that employees' work–life balance significantly impacts job engagement. Research has shown that work-life balance cannot be treated in isolation, as factors such as job engagement and perceived organizational support are closely related to it (Le et al., 2020). Studies have also found that work-life balance directly influences job engagement (Jaharuddin & Zainol, 2019). However, achieving work-life balance will lead to greater employee job engagement, commitment, and performance (Jaharuddin & Zainol, 2019). The study of Jaharuddin and Zainol (2019) also revealed a direct relationship between work-life balance, job engagement, and turnover intentions, and reported that work-life balance explains 24% of the variance in turnover intentions. In general, the findings of these studies indicate that the greater the work-life balance, the more engaged and satisfied employees are with their jobs and the less likely they are to quit.

This impacts an organization's development and adaptability and plays a pivotal role in shaping morale, productivity, initiative, and loyalty among employees, thereby impacting internal and external stakeholders (Rollnik-Sadowska et al., 2023). Employees become engaged when they are ready to pay for hard work, enthusiastic about the job, motivated to work, and concerned about the positions they hold within the organization (Horváthová et al., 2019). Job engagement can be assessed by how loyal employees are to the organization, their enthusiasm, and their match of personal values with the organization's mission statement and goals.

Courier jobs in the Caraga region of the Philippines, particularly for parcel delivery, entail high physical demands from navigating rural roads, handling heavy loads on motorcycles or vans, and enduring extreme weather like heavy rains during typhoons, often spanning 10-12 hour shifts without fixed breaks. According to Palanca et al. (2022), these couriers face irregular schedules driven by e-commerce demands from regional firms like Jades Cargo, involving multiple daily stops across provinces such as Agusan del Sur or Surigao del Norte amid poor infrastructure like unpaved paths. According to regional logistics insights from Transportify (2023), parcel handlers in Caraga manage 20-50 packages per route, exposed to traffic risks and isolation without real-time support, relying on performance incentives amid fuel cost fluctuations. According to ADB analyses adapted to Mindanao (2022), flexibility appeals to local couriers aged 25-40, mostly males, but unpredictable volumes erode recovery time, heightening fatigue in remote areas. According to Republic Courier patterns (2025), constant GPS tracking and customer interactions blur work-life boundaries, with minimal safety gear provided by firms operating in Caraga.

Age

Santrock (2021) stated that age refers to the length of time that the person has lived, often measured in years, and is commonly used as a basic demographic variable to describe individuals within a population. (Fernandez et al., 2022) found a relationship between perceptions of work-

life balance and age. The results illustrate differences in how younger, middle-aged, and older employees perceive work-life balance. Age is a demographic variable consistently examined in relation to employee experiences, though its effects vary across different outcomes. In the context of job stress, younger employees appear to be more vulnerable. A study conducted at a Philippine agricultural college found a significant negative correlation between age and job stress, indicating that younger employees reported higher levels of job stress (Esguerra, 2020). Conversely, research on work-life balance (WLB) presents a more complex picture. A study within the scholarly publishing industry revealed that the youngest cohort of employees is the most engaged. (20-35 years) reported better WLBs than their middle-aged counterparts (36-65 years) (Fernandez & Lebin, 2022). This suggests that the challenges of balancing work and life may intensify during mid-career stages, due to increasing family and professional duties.

Gragnano, Simbula, and Miglioretti (2020) state that age is essential in understanding how labor practices influence work-life balance. Work-life balance contributes to reducing job stress, anxiety, and depression among older workers (Haar, Harris, and Myers 2024). There may be critical lessons individuals can learn from older generations and employees about work-life balance (Fernandez et al., 2022).

Sex

Sex, is a crucial variable in examining workplace dynamics, as societal roles and structural imbalances often influence organizational aspects, affecting experiences related to job satisfaction, work-life balance, and safety. Sex, both in terms of biological differences and sexual well-being, plays a significant role in the workplace by influencing job satisfaction, productivity, and overall employee well- being seems possible that biological Sex could affect the way in which work is both socially and emotionally experienced and, as a result, influence biological response.

The purpose of this study was to examine the role of biological Sex in moderating the relationship between workplace culture and preclinical biomarkers of health (Hart et al., 2024).

According to Lagrana (2021), men and women experience different levels of work-life balance and job satisfaction. An examination of non-standard agency workers in the Philippines revealed significant differences by Sex: female workers reported higher job satisfaction, while male workers reported a superior work-life balance. This might mean that women might find their jobs more fulfilling, even with the great difficulty in work and family life. Other studies, however, do not discover such a difference. An analysis of the publishing industry found no statistically significant difference in perceptions of work-life balance between gender groups (Fernandez, 2022). In the same way, a cross-sectional body of older adults discovered that the caffeine-sleep and health relationship was not equally significant across Sex, with caffeine abstinence connected with worse sleep among females. In contrast, the opposite was true among males, suggesting gender-specific physiological or behavioral reactions (van der Linden et al., 2023).

Gender inequalities are even more pronounced when it comes to research on the platform or gig economy, especially in areas traditionally perceived as male, such as ride-hailing and delivery services. A study in Argentina revealed prevalent gender differences in working hours and income. These differences are primarily due to women's working hours and earnings being constrained by the unequal distribution of care and increased safety risks, leading to a reluctance to accept risky night and weekend shifts (Micha et al., 2022). These findings are supported by qualitative studies of female platform drivers in China and India, which show that there remains a difficult choice between earning and balancing the responsibility of taking care of children and overcoming the threat of dying in accidents (Ghosh and Kuttan, 2022; Kwan, 2022). These articles suggest that the flexibility provided by platform work tends to reinforce the gendered division of labor, as women must balance paid and unpaid labor. Yet, it does not grant them the stability

needed to become economically empowered (Ghosh and Kuttan, 2022). The algorithmic management systems on platforms may also help punish women because of work patterns shaped by preexisting gendered restrictions (Micha et al., 2022). Therefore, although quantitative studies can provide both positive and adverse evidence, qualitative evidence strongly indicates that gender is a fundamental determinant that organizes women's experiences and reduces their chances in the contemporary workforce.

Civil Status

Civil status is a demographic factor that often correlates with an employee's personal responsibilities and, consequently, their experience of work-related stress and work-life balance. The correlation between work-life balance and work culture is well established in research on working parents in Hong Kong, a city known for its strong work ethic. Based on a large-scale population survey, the study found that single or widowed participants experienced much greater work-life stress than their married or cohabiting respondents (Chen and Cheung, 2022). The same result underscores the potential supportive role of a partner in managing the demands of two-family work life. Without this support, single parents like the example could be left to manage the entire responsibility of raising children and maintaining the household while also attending to their jobs, which increases their stress levels.

The paper also underscores the importance of the family domain, showing that stress was strongly and negatively correlated with satisfaction with family life (Chen and Cheung, 2022). This means that a balanced family life, easily attained with a partner, is a primary source of well-being and an essential asset in dealing with work stressors. Although the literature reviewed did not provide much data regarding civil status in a broad span of industries, the data provided by the Hong Kong study is an indication that marital status is a salient factor in the work-life dynamic, which determines the degree of stress employees experience as they juggle between the

professional and personal realms. This underscores that civil status is more than a simple demographic category; it often represents a key element of an individual's social support network, which can directly impact their ability to manage work demands and achieve well-being. At the same time, many studies include civil status as a variable in demographic profiles (Esguerra, 2020; Lagrana & Bayoneta, 2021). The direct isolated impact of marital status, outside the context of broader family support systems, warrants further exploration in the literature.

Educational Attainment

Educational attainment is a term statisticians commonly use to refer to the highest degree an individual has completed. Successful completion of a level of education means achieving the learning objectives of that level, typically validated through assessments of the knowledge, skills, and competencies acquired. Research involving a group of workers engaged with an agricultural college in the Philippines established a significant negative relationship between job stress and educational attainment (Esguerra, 2020). This result suggests that employees with higher levels of education reported experiencing less job stress. According to the study, this association may be due to higher education improving coping mechanisms or preparing individuals to work in occupations that, although challenging, offer greater control over work —a known stress-mitigating factor.

According to Lagrana & Bayoneta (2021), younger and less educated workers were more susceptible to work-related stress, and management should assist the target group (Esgueria, 2020). This finding aligns with the broader understanding that education can be a resource that enhances an individual's capacity to navigate workplace challenges. It is often included as a standard variable in demographic analyses to understand its role in influencing employee outcomes. Although the broader pool of studies in the review was not always concerned with educational attainment as a key variable, this result in the Philippines indicates that it may be an

essential moderator in the stress process. It is also consistent with broader sociological findings that education is a necessary element of human capital, which can lead to improved employment and well-being. For organizations, investing in employee development and providing educational opportunities may not only enhance skills but also serve as a long-term strategy for building a more resilient and less-stressed workforce. Further research across different sectors would be beneficial to determine the generalizability of this relationship between educational level and job stress.

Years of Experience

Years of experience are a critical factor, particularly in occupations that involve high levels of skill and risk, such as operating a delivery vehicle. Years of experience are a significant demographic factor indicating how long an employee has been working in a specific position, industry, or the workforce at large. It is commonly associated with skill level, knowledge, and career advancement. A comprehensive scoping review of risk factors for injuries among two-wheeled food delivery riders identified a lack of driving experience as one of the most commonly cited contributors to occupational injuries (McKinlay et al., 2022).

A scoping review of international research on injuries among two-wheeled food delivery riders found that the most frequently mentioned risk factor for accidents is a lack of driving experience, with youthful age another (McKinlay et al., 2022). This observation is reasonable because novice riders may lack hazard perception skills, familiarity with traffic accidents, and defensive riding skills. The stressful delivery work that often prioritizes speed can also increase the risks for those new to the job. This observation has been supported by research on p-hailing (food and parcel delivery) riders in Malaysia, which examined certain dangerous riding behaviors.

According to Abdullah and Rose (2025), the less experienced riders were much more likely to engage in unsafe behaviors, such as accelerating to nearly a red light or ignoring road

signs. This implies that experience can do more than enhance technical competencies; it can also make one more mature and more careful about the risks associated with on-the-job training. In the case of courier and delivery companies, the findings are straightforward: new riders are a high-risk population that should be subjected to greater training, mentoring, and supervision in the first months of employment to reduce the risk of accidents. Although the literature mainly focuses on experience as a factor affecting safety outcomes, it is an essential element in the context of employee vulnerability when operating under high workloads.

Years in Business

The success of a business is now significantly influenced by employee engagement and retention. The logistics industry has particular difficulties in keeping and motivating workers because of arduous work environments, erratic scheduling, and the emotional and physical strain of the job. Nevertheless, the industry is also facing several obstacles that can hinder and constrain this progress. One significant factor that has often been highlighted is the shortage of labor in the logistics company. Despite the advances in digitization and automation, logistics is still a labor-intensive industry (Moh, 2023)A courier company provides commercial package delivery service to customers over small and large distances. The courier industry in the U.S. emerged more than a hundred years ago, and it has seen rapid growth in the last few decades, mostly due to globalization and e-commerce. This industry will likely keep its momentum going into the future (Zhang et al., 2021).

The Rubberization of work in the platformed on-demand courier goods distribution and the delivery phenomenon has been on the rise in the past decade because of the continuous growth of neoliberalism and expansion of capitalism—and with the evolution and expansion of information and communication technologies—creating new ways and reconfigurations of work and labor (Leonardi and Pirina, 2020). The gig economy saw its emergence and boom alongside

the Great Recession period and, therefore, the subprime crisis of 2008 (Vallas and Schor, 2020), with the loss of bargaining power of the workers and rising unemployment. As of now, it is growing to be one of the most present and influential spheres of the economy worldwide, with an expectation of reaching $455 billion in 2023, representing a growth of 17.4% when compared with 2018 (Broda, 2022). It currently represents “an important and strategically consequential branch of global capitalism”, playing an important role in domestic and global labor markets (Vallas and Schor, 2020).

The concept of the gig economy advocates for the part of the labor markets characterized by independent contingent contracting arrangements developed and carried through digital platforms (Woodcock and Graham, 2020). Vallas and Schor (2020) define two types of branches, per se, in the gig economy: within the conventional economy, where already established corporations digitalize businesses with others; and the new consequential branch where various companies are already born and created in digital platforms. Currently, there are some studies on this considerably new phenomenon that is these on demand courier services, even considering the need for more exploration and information on it. If we look at the main research that has been made about this activity, it is safe to say that overall, around the globe, the different platforms in different places tend to have a very similar type of structure and operate the same, with non-remarkable differences.

Job Position

A position in an organizational context refers to a specific role or seat within an organizational structure occupied by an individual. It defines the exact tasks, responsibilities, authority, and qualifications required for that role within the company’s hierarchy. A position is distinct to a person and situation, and it serves as the foundation for employee placement, ensuring clarity in workflow, accountability, and organizational structure. According to

ThriveSparrow (2025), a job position clarifies the role for a particular employee, outlining their duties and responsibilities and supporting efficient task delegation and team cohesion (ThriveSparrow, 2025).

Since the necessary support for the e-commerce industry comes from courier companies, including receiving, sorting, packaging, transportation, distribution, and other processes (Pang et al., 2023). Another study that deals with emerging trends and how they will change the logistics sector is the dissertation from Daniek Scholte Lubberink (2021) at the University of Twente. The study analyzes nine (9) professions for which there is no particular grouping. This research aims to identify the differences in the required competencies/skills in future jobs in four value chain activities: purchasing department, logistics, marketing, and human resources management (HRM).

The reviewed literature shows that labor practices and work-life balance among courier employees are closely interconnected and shaped by both organizational and individual factors. Demographic characteristics such as age, sex, civil status, educational attainment, job position, years of experience, and years in business influence how couriers perceive work demands, stress, and balance between personal and professional life. Core labor practices including work environment, working conditions, health and safety, education and training, perceived fairness, and psychological safety consistently emerge as key determinants of job satisfaction, work stress, and overall well-being. In the courier and gig economy context, heavy workloads, long working hours, and performance pressures intensify stress and work-life imbalance, often leading to burnout and turnover intention. On the other hand , supportive and fair labor practices, safe working environments, adequate training, and organizational concern for employee welfare foster psychological safety, job engagement, and satisfaction, which in turn enhance work-life balance and reduce stress and intention to quit. Overall, the literature underscores that improving labor

practices is essential to promoting sustainable work-life balance, employee well-being, and retention among courier employees.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

Labor Practices consist of variables which include work environment, work conditions, health and safety, education and training, perceived fairness, psychological safety, and job satisfaction (Pang et al., 2023). In addition, work-life balance, according to Gragnano et al. (2020), encompasses not only work–family balance but also emphasizes the significance of health and other non-work domains, especially for diverse workers. This study adopted Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs, Equity, and Job Demand-Resource (JD-R). These theories provide a theoretical foundation that helps explain how labor practices influence work-life balance among courier employees by linking their motivation, fairness perception, and work conditions. Thus, work-life balance initiatives enhance worker well-being and sustain productivity in the dynamic, decentralized environment of courier employees.

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

According to Maslow's hierarchy of needs by Abraham Maslow (1943), human beings are motivated to achieve a pyramid of five fundamental needs hierarchically, with the most basic being a need to survive, and then the successive need to belong, which is followed by a need to be honored, and finally, a need to realize self. The five levels of needs are physiological, safety, belonging, esteem, and self-actualization. Physiological needs include food, air, and water. Safety needs involve security and stability. Belonging and love require affection. Esteem needs involve mastery of the environment and societal recognition. Self-actualization consists of maximizing one's unique potential, leading to peak experiences and transcendence. Self-esteem must be met before people can be motivated by higher-level needs, such as self-actualization (Bozyiğit, 2021; Hopper, 2020; Valliani, 2021).

Researchers and organizations continue to use this theory to understand human behavior and apply it widely to business and corporate management (Stefan et al., 2020). Therefore, this study further divided the Maslow hierarchy into three sub-components based on the needs of employees: physiological, safety, and social needs, consisting of health and safety, working environment, working conditions, and esteem needs that include perceived fairness; and self-actualization, which consists of satisfaction. In addition to these, changes in the socio-political and economic structure of societies affect both the nature of employment and the relationship of individuals outside of working life. This situation has adverse effects on the lifestyle of many people. The employees' socio-psychological health is affected, and the issue of work-life balance arises (Atheya & Arora, 2014).

Equity Theory

Equity theory by Adams (1965) is also widely used in the field of corporate management as a classic theory that can explain employee job satisfaction (Kollmann et al., 2020). Equity theory holds that any employment relationship is an exchange between an employee and an organization (Klein, 1973). In this relationship, the ratio (i.e., perceived fairness) between the outcomes received by the employees and their inputs determines the satisfaction of the employees Kollmann, 2020). In that exchange relationship, an employee's job satisfaction results from the ratio between outcomes and inputs (Lawler, 1973). Outcomes are rewards that employees receive from their organizations (e.g., pay). Inputs are contributions that employees give to their organizations (e.g., work effort). Employees feel satisfied when there is equity (i.e., balance) between what they receive and what they give to the organization (Huseman & Hatfield, 1990). However, when outcomes do not match inputs, this inequity leads to dissonance and job dissatisfaction (Pritchard, 1969).

Fairness in the workplace, encompassing employees' perceptions of equity and justice, is pivotal in shaping organizational dynamics Greenberg, 1990). It aligns with Adams's Equity Theory, which posits that fairness perceptions directly influence employee motivation and satisfaction, laying the groundwork for higher organizational commitment and performance Adams, 1965). Extensive research has validated this relationship, with studies demonstrating that perceived fairness correlates with a range of positive employee outcomes, such as enhanced job satisfaction, increased trust, and greater engagement (Colquitt et al., 2001; Abbas et al., 2018). Empirical evidence further underscores the impact of fairness on engagement, illustrating that fairness not only promotes general work satisfaction but also fosters organizational citizenship behaviors, a key indicator of deep engagement (Na-Nan et al., 2020; Rahman MHA, Karim DN, 2022).

Job Demands-Control Model Theory

According to the Job Demands Control Mode Theory, formulated by Karasek in 1979, work stress may arise from high job demands, such as a large workload, and a lack of control over work (Annisa et al., 2024). Based on this theory, work stress occurs due to a high workload. This statement is supported by research conducted by Wirawan (2022), which also states that excessive workloads cause work stress in employees.

This study is grounded in the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model, which provides a comprehensive framework for examining how workplace factors influence employee outcomes. The JD-R model posits that job demands such as Workload, role ambiguity, and time pressure require sustained physical and psychological effort, potentially leading to strain and burnout. On the other hand, work-life balance (WLB) programs and technological assistance are also available as job resources that reduce the adverse impact of such demands by enhancing positive outcomes, e.g., higher job satisfaction and productivity (Demerouti et al., 2001).

This model theorizes that the range of control over one's environmental situation is a crucial dimension in determining health on the one hand, and active behavior/learning on the other (Karasek et al., 1998). Specifically, jobs combining high demands and low control (i.e., high-strain jobs) are the worst context for a worker's health (job strain hypothesis). Previous studies have shown that both high demands and low control at work endanger the work–home balance and increase the likelihood of work–family conflict. High job demands, such as quantitative Workload among medical residents (Geurts, Rutte, & Peeters, 1999) and long work hours among private-sector employees (Major, Klein, & Ehrhart, 2002), have been associated with work–home interference. Given that the demands and control opportunities at work are related to the extent of conflicts between work and family roles, it would be essential to pay attention to possible mediators of this association as well as to factors that might help to reduce work-family conflict, for example, by buffering the effects of high demands on family life.

1.4 Schematic Diagram

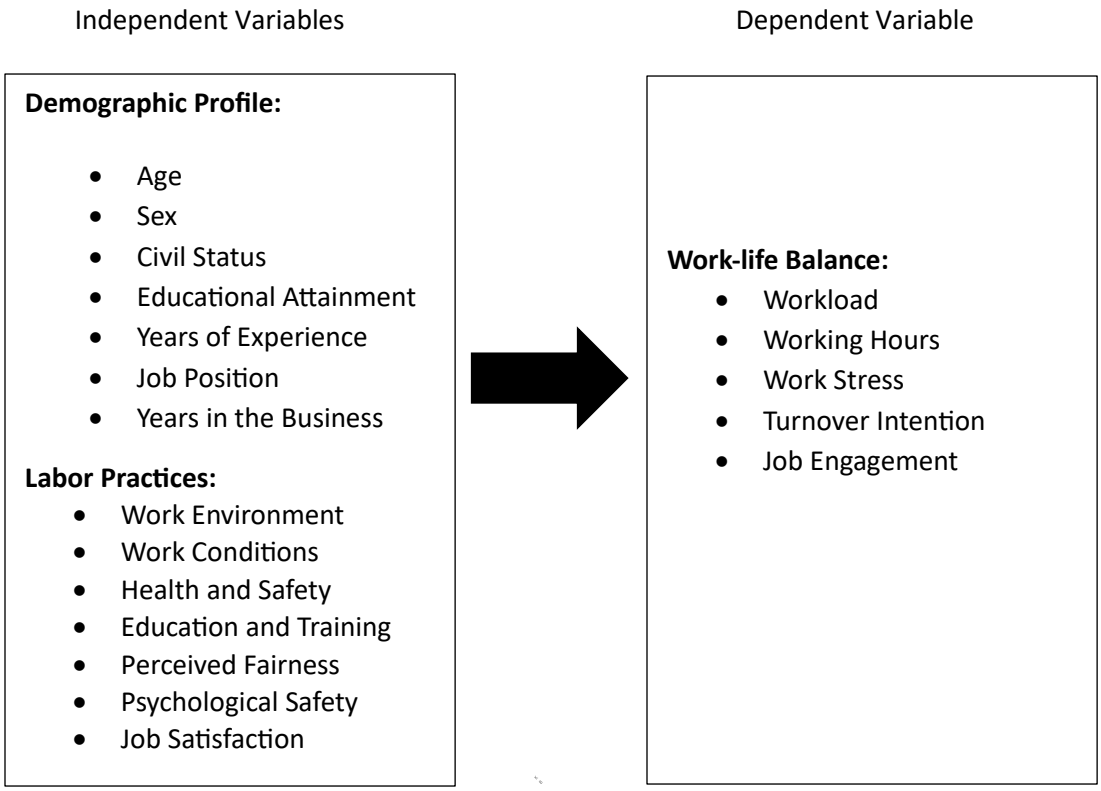


Figure 1. The schematic diagram illustrates the interplay between the independent and dependent variables of the study.

1.5 Statement of the Problem

This study aims to explore the relationship between labor practices and work-life balance among courier employees.

Specifically seek to answer the following questions:

1. What is the demographic profile of the courier employees, in terms of:

    1.1. Age;

    1.2. Sex;

    1.3. Civil Status;

    1.4. Educational Attainment;

    1.5. Years of Experience;

    1.6. Job Position; and

    1.7. Years in Business?

2. What is the level of labor practices among courier employees, in terms of:

    2.1 Work Environment;

    2.2 Work Conditions;

    2.3 Health and safety;

    2.4 Education and Training;

    2.5 Perceived Fairness;

    2.6 Psychological Safety; and

    2.7 Job Satisfaction?

3. What is the level of Work Life Balance among courier employees, in terms of:

    3.1 Workload;

    3.2 Working Hours;

    3.3 Work Stress;

3.4 Turnover Intention; and

3.5 Job Engagement?

4. Is there a significant relationship between the Labor Practices among courier employees and Work-Life Balance?

1.6 Hypothesis

The hypothesis guided the study and tested at $\alpha = 0.05$ level of significance.

H_0: There is no significant relationship between labor practices and the work-life balance of courier employees.

H_1: There is a significant relationship between labor practices and the work-life balance of courier employees.

1.7 Scope and Limitations

This study will investigate how labor practices will have a relationship with work-life balance among the courier employees, specifically in the courier employees at Flash Express, J&T Express, JRS Express, and SPX Express that are located in Buenavista, Naispit, and Carmen.

The researchers intend to use stratified random sampling to ensure that courier employees from different logistic companies and areas in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen are fairly included in the study. This research study will be conducted during the school year 2025-2026 by the Human Resource Management students. The study will take place at logistic companies such as J&T Express and SPX Express at Buenavista, Flash Express, and JRS Express at Nasipit, and J&T in Carmen.

1.8 Definition of Terms

For a better understanding and classification, the following terms and words are operationally defined as follows:

Age: Defined as the number of years a courier employees has lived since birth.

Civil Status: Refers to the courier employees' official marital status, including being single, married, divorced, separated, widowed, or in a civil partnership.

Couriers Employees: It refers to workers who are hired by logistic companies which includes, managers/supervisors/admins/hub lead, hr, finance, hub coordinator, backroom, and delivery riders that transport, deliver, and collect documents, parcels, or packages, from one location to another.

Educational Attainment: It refers to the highest level of formal education that a courier employee has completed.

Education and Training: Are the formal and informal learning opportunities for courier employees to improve their job performance and professionalism.

Health and Safety: Refers to the physical and mental conditions of courier employee that affect their well-being. This includes providing rest days to prevent stress and fatigue, and protective equipment to avoid road accidents.

Job Engagement: Refers to the level of enthusiasm, involvement, and commitment courier employees have toward their work.

Job Position: It refers to a specific role that is assigned to courier employees within a logistics company.

Job Satisfaction: Refers to the courier employee's job performance, whether they are happy and contented, how they are treated, their pay, and how safe they are while performing their job.

Labor Practices: Refer to the actual methods and conditions of work experienced by the courier employee, including their wages, safety measures while on duty, working hours, and their ability to express concerns or organize.

Perceived Fairness: Refers to fair wages, benefits, and compensation, and how courier employees feel treated by customers and employers in their work.

Psychological Safety: Refers to expressing concerns about what the courier employee feels and asking for help without fear of negative consequences.

Relationship: Refers to the measurable connection between labor practices and work-life balance among courier employee.

Sex: Refers to the biological trait that determines whether a sexually reproducing organism produces male or female gametes.

Turnover Intention: Refers to the likelihood or intention to leave their current job or stop working as a courier employee.

Work-Life Balance: Refers to the amount of time that a courier employee spend doing their job compared with the amount of time they spend with their family and doing things they enjoy.

Work Conditions: Refers to the physical and non-physical environments where a courier employee perform their jobs, including rules, comfort, Workload, and compensation.

Work Environment: Refers to the surroundings and situations in which courier employees perform their tasks

Working Hours: Refers to the length of time courier employees spend on duty or actively working each day.

Workload: Refers to the number of tasks or deliveries assigned to a courier employee within a specific period.

Work Stress: Refers to the pressure or strain that courier employees experience while performing their job due to Workload and time pressure.

Years in Business: It refers to the length of a company's operation. The business officially started its operation up to the present year.

Years of Experience: Refers to the number of years a courier employee has worked in a particular field or industry, accumulating skills and knowledge relevant to that area.

CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

This chapter will present the Research Design, Research Materials and Methods, Research Environment, Population and Sample, Research Data and Analysis Plan, and Research Ethical Standards.

2.1 Research Design

The study will employ a descriptive-correlational research design describe as existing variables and examines the relationship between them without manipulating any conditions. to explore the relationship between labor practices and work-life balance among courier employees at Company A, Company B, Company C, and Company D. The descriptive element will help describe in a systematic manner the current labor practices and the degree of work-life balance among the courier workers. This methodology will allow the researchers to describe an honest depiction of the current working conditions of the respondents without manipulating any variables. The correlational aspect of the design will be applied to test the connection between the labor practices and work-life balance. This study design will be suitable since the major aim is not to prove the cause and effect but to understand whether a significant relationship exists between the variables in their natural occurrence within the workplace.

2.2 Research Locale

The study will be conducted at Logistic Companies such as Company A, Company B, Company C, and Company D that are located at Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen which are neighboring municipalities in Agusan del Norte, with Buenavista known for its coastal agriculture, Nasipit for its strategic port and commerce, and Carmen for its fertile inland farmlands. In these municipalities, courier employees play a vital role in connecting businesses and residents through efficient delivery services. Location A, Buenavista, has two logistics companies, such as Company

B and Company D, while Location B, Nasipit, has three: Company A, Company B, and Company C and Location C, Carmen has one: Company B. Company D, the logistics arm of Sea Limited and Shopee, has an established presence in the Caraga region with a hub in Buenavista, Agusan del Norte, while Company B in Buenavista provides delivery and pickup services through nearby branch routes to support nationwide e-commerce. In Nasipit, Agusan del Norte, Company B operates as a local drop-off and pickup point, alongside Company A, which offers nationwide next-day delivery and 24/7 service, and Company C, a major Filipino courier with a local branch serving the area. Meanwhile, in Carmen, Agusan del Norte, Company B continues to expand its express delivery services, supporting e-commerce growth through advanced technology, real-time tracking, and an extensive network of branches and drop points.

The study's respondents will be the courier employees from these companies, and to gather the necessary data, the researchers personally administered survey questionnaires and employed a descriptive research design to determine the number of respondents.

The selection of these destinations and logistics firms was based on the fact that they were the only courier service providers that operated in the selected municipalities, which will enable the researchers to carry out the research. Their willingness will guarantee the accessibility of respondents and facilitate the process of data-gathering, and allow the research to proceed within the stipulated research scope.

2.3 Research Environment, Population, and Sample

Table 1. *Distribution of the Respondents by Logistics Company and Position*

Logistic Companies	Position	*n*	Population	Frequency	Percentage
Company A	Supervisors	2			
	Employees	29	46	33	28.45%
	Delivery Riders	15			
Company B	Managers/ Supervisors/Admins	12			
	Employees	4	72	51	43.97%
	Delivery Riders	56			
Company C	In Charge	1	2	1	0.86%
	Rider	1			
Company D	Hub Lead	1			
	Employees	7	43	31	26.72%
	Delivery Riders	35			
TOTAL			**163**	**116**	**100%**

The data will be collected from different logistics companies operating at Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. Based on the data shown in the table above, the study will have 116 courier employees in total as respondents.

To guarantee that all the courier employees from Company A, Company B, Company C, and Company D will be observed in the sample, the research will use stratified random sampling; hereby the population of courier employees will be divided based on the municipality of assignment, that is, Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. Each stratum will then be proportionally selected to form representatives of courier employees within the chosen areas fairly. Information will be collected using a structured survey questionnaire designed to measure the relationship between labor practices and work-life balance.

The main research instrument will be a structured survey questionnaire, modified from an existing, validated study and specifically developed to address the research objectives and variables. The studies that will be modified are entitled "Increasing Couriers' Job Satisfaction through Social-Sustainability Practices: Perceived Fairness and Psychological-Safety Perspectives" authored by Pang et al. (2023), which consists of the variables such as work environment, work conditions, health and safety, education and training, perceived fairness, psychological safety, and job satisfaction. The second study, entitled "Workload and working hours effect on employees' work-life balance mediated by work stress" by Natanael et al. (2023), consists of variables such as Workload, working hours, and work stress. Lastly, it is from the study entitled "The Impact of Work-Life Balance on Job Engagement and Turnover Intention" by Nor Siah Jaharuddin and Liyana Nadia Zainol (2019). These studies were the basis for creating the research instrument.

To ensure the validity and reliability of the research instrument, a systematic validation process and pilot testing will be conducted prior to the actual data gathering. Expert evaluation will be used to determine content validity. A questionnaire will be given to a panel of experts who will consist of people who are well-equipped in the field of labor studies, human resource management, and research methodology. The validity of the research tool will be determined by pilot testing with at least thirty (30) respondents similar to the respondents but will not be used in the final data gathering. The pilot test will be aimed at establishing the consistency and internal reliability of the questionnaire. The structured survey questionnaire was adapted from previously validated studies; however, modifications will be made to align the instrument with the present research objectives and context of courier employees. Thus, further validation was necessary to ensure that the items accurately measure the intended variables.

The survey questionnaire will consist of three parts: (1) the demographic profile of the respondents, including age, sex, civil status, educational attainment, years of experience, years in

business, and job position; (2) items measuring the level of labor practices including work environment, work conditions, health and safety, perceived fairness, and job satisfaction; (3) items measuring the work-life balance, including Workload, working hours, work stress, job engagement, and turnover intention. These parts of the survey questionnaire will explore the relationship between labor practices and work-life balance among the courier employees.

The instrument will use a Likert scale format to measure the degree of agreement with each statement. The interpretation of Likert scale will result in exploring the relationship of labor practices on work-life balance among courier employees. It will use a 4-point rating scale, where a score of 4 "Strongly Agree, a score of 3 "Agree", a score of 2 "Disagree", and a score of 1 "Strongly Disagree". This scale will be used to evaluate the strength of respondents' perceptions regarding the labor practices and work-life balance. The researchers will give a Bisaya (Cebuano) translation of every survey questionnaire item to reduce the likelihood of language barrier and misunderstanding of the questions written in English.

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

With the Adviser and Dean's approval, the researchers requested permission from the Municipal Offices to obtain the number of logistic companies. After obtaining the list of logistic companies, the researchers will request permission from each company head to gather information on the total population of their regular workers. Upon receiving respondents' consent, survey forms were distributed, and respondents were given sufficient time to complete them. Once completed, the questionnaires were collected and analyzed, with the mean of responses calculated to summarize the findings.

Letter of Approval. The researchers submitted a letter of request to the Municipality's Mayor and the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI), or the Business Permit and Licensing Office (BPLO), to validate the study and secure permission to proceed, as well as to obtain the list

of logistic companies in each municipality. After acquiring the official list, the researchers sought permission from the heads of the identified logistic companies to gather information regarding the total population of their regular workers.

Orientation. The researchers will conduct an orientation for the respondents to inform them about the study and ensure they understand the ethical agreements.

Distribution of Informed Consent Form. The researchers will distribute informed consent forms to the respondents, which will serve as agreements confirming that they understood their rights and were free to agree or decline to participate in the study.

Distribution of Questionnaire. The researchers will personally distribute the survey questionnaires to the respondents. Respondents will be given ample time to provide the information required for the study.

Retrieval of the Questionnaire and Consent Form. After the allotted time, the researchers will personally retrieve the completed questionnaires and consent forms to prepare for data collection.

Gathering of Data. The data will be collected, checked for completeness, tallied, presented, analyzed, and interpreted using appropriate statistical techniques and tools.

The analysis of the data obtained will be performed with the help of coding, tabulation, and arrangement with the help of proper statistical software. The descriptive statistics to be employed in describing labor practices and work-life balance of courier workers will include frequency, percentage, weighted mean, and standard deviation.

In order to establish the connection between labor practices and work-life balance, the inferential statistical methods, namely correlation analysis, will be used. The interpretation of the results will be made depending on the purpose of the study, and the level of statistical significance that is acceptable.

Statistical Treatment

The data gathered from the survey questionnaires will be collected, organized, tabulated, and analyzed using the following statistical tools:

Frequency and Percentage. This tool will be used to determine the demographic profile of the courier employees.

Mean. This tool will be used to determine the level of labor practices and the level of work-life balance among courier employees.

Pearson Correlation Coefficient. The Pearson Correlation Coefficient measures the strength and direction of the linear relationship between two continuous variables.

will be used to evaluate the relationship between labor practices and work-life balance to identify the strength and direction of the linear relationship between them.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Protection of Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This research did not include the development of new technology, techniques, or products that would have required patent protection. However, the study may consist of original elements, such as questionnaires, which might be copyrighted in order to safeguard the study's particular contribution. The researcher will base the research instrument on three existing studies, which have already been published, and ask the authors of these works to provide formal consent to use and revise the questionnaire items that will be selected.

B. Informed Consent

Every individual who will be invited to participate in the study was provided with an informed consent form that clearly explained the purpose of the research, procedures involved, possible risks, and expected outcomes. Participation in the study was entirely voluntary, and participants were informed that they could refuse to participate or withdraw at any time without

any penalty or negative consequences. Signing the informed consent form signified the participant's voluntary agreement to take part after fully understanding the nature of the study. This process ensured respect for the respondents' autonomy, confidentiality, and right to make an informed decision regarding their participation.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The researchers maintain and protect the confidentiality of participants in this study in accordance with data privacy regulations, ensuring that no personal or sensitive information is compromised. All data provided by the researchers is ensured to be protected, and no respondents will be pinpointed after the surveys are conducted. The researchers guarantee that privacy protection safeguards the confidentiality of study participants and the specific organizations involved. The data collected will be safely discarded once the study has been completed. Any digital files will be destroyed forever from any storage device, and any printed documents will be shredded to guarantee confidentiality.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom and Withdrawal

In this study, the respondents were volunteers who chose to participate. The selected delivery rider employees at Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen(BueNasCar) are not obliged to continue the survey if the respondents believe it caused harm emotionally or physically. The voluntary method gave respondents a sense of free will and encouraged them to commit their time and effort to participating in the study. No conflict of interest will exist as the courier companies mentioned will not fund or influence the study.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

The researchers designed the study to minimize potential harm to all the respondents by carefully selecting and making the survey questionnaires safe, and avoiding physical, psychological, or emotional harm. Respondents were informed of the objective, procedure,

possible risks, and rights. If harm and danger arise, support is provided, such as emergency hotlines, therapy sessions given by professionals, and immediate assistance. This strategy supported the respondent's well-being while maintaining ethical standards throughout the course of the research study. This research adheres to ethical standards of research, as the participants were allowed to participate voluntarily, anonymously and confidentially. No personal data shall be gathered and all the responses shall be safely stored and reported in a generic manner. A non-retaliation policy will be employed to prevent any negative impacts accruing to the respondents by giving an honest, including negative, response.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

The goal of the study is to provide Courier Employees specifying on the delivery riders with valuable insights regarding labor practices and work-life balance while also having a good influence on society and the academic community. The results will assist the courier industry in determining what work-life balance and labor practices to offer all employees. The responders will be granted access upon request once the research findings are finished.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

The respondents were selected through a fair and transparent process based on predetermined inclusion criteria. Participants were required to be currently employed as courier employees and to have a minimum of six months of work experience to ensure adequate familiarity with prevailing labor practices and work–life balance conditions. Selection was conducted without discrimination based on personal characteristics such as age, gender, or employment status. This approach ensured an objective and representative sample, thereby supporting a comprehensive analysis of labor practices and work–life balance among courier employees.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

The researchers will use clear and organized methods to ensure accurate and consistent data collection and analysis. To maintain objectivity, access to the data was limited to the researchers. The researchers also consider potential biases and limitations that could affect the results, such as sampling issues or unclear responses. When some respondents left parts of the survey unanswered, the researchers respectfully followed up and asked them to complete the missing items to ensure the data was valid and complete. To address these concerns, the survey will be validated by experts, incomplete forms will be carefully managed, and all findings will be reported honestly. These efforts will help uphold ethical standards and reinforce the study's credibility.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

The findings of this study will be presented with complete honesty and transparency, ensuring that the data gathered was neither omitted, misinterpreted, nor altered. All previously published and copyrighted materials were properly acknowledged and cited. AI tools will be utilized to enhance and refine information relevant to specific aspects of the ongoing research.

J. Use of Patented or Copyright materials

The study did not use any patented materials. The researchers cited all copyrighted materials, including related literature, and obtained necessary permissions.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

Ethical considerations require a deep understanding of the study's effects, benefits, and potential risks. The researchers informed respondents that this study would not involve physical risks, as it focuses solely on their responses. However, proper support services were made available if necessary. Since no animals were involved, ethical animal use clearance was not

required. The focus was solely on human respondents, with sufficient ethical frameworks and procedures to ensure their safety and obtain informed consent.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Related Technologies

The researchers used AI tools such as Grammarly and QuillBot to help improve the grammar and clarity of the study. These tools were used only as support and not to replace the researchers' own thinking and judgment. All ideas, analysis, and conclusions were carefully reviewed and decided by the researchers themselves. By using AI responsibly and checking all outputs, the researchers made sure the study remained accurate, credible, and ethical.

M. Ethical Approval

The research will propose ethical approval from the ethics committee and the Research and Instructional Innovation Department (RIID) of Saint Michael College of Caraga.

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Membership/Affiliations

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